ROYAL FITNESS CLUB

Fitness Foundations Certificate

MODULE 3

Beginner Training Program Design

Duration	40 minutes
Course Code	CS_B1
Level	Beginner
Format	Study Guide PDF

Part of the Royal Fitness Club Professional Certification Program.

SECTION 1: Why Program Design Matters

Random Exercise vs Structured Programming

The difference between people who consistently make progress and those who spin their wheels for years often comes down to one thing: structured programming. Random exercise produces random results. A well-designed programme provides a systematic stimulus that drives measurable, predictable adaptation over weeks, months, and years.

A training programme is a written document specifying the exercises, sets, reps, tempo, rest periods, frequency, and progression model for a training period (typically 4–12 weeks). It removes guesswork and creates accountability.

What a Good Programme Provides
• Specificity — exercises match the goal (strength, hypertrophy, fat loss, sport)
• Progressive overload — built-in progression model prevents adaptation plateau
• Volume management — enough stimulus to grow; not so much to overtrain
• Frequency — each muscle group trained often enough for continuous protein synthesis
• Recovery — adequate rest between sessions and deload protocols
• Balance — pushing/pulling, anterior/posterior, upper/lower ratios maintained

SECTION 2: Sets, Reps, and Intensity

Decoding Training Notation

Exercise prescriptions use shorthand notation. Understanding this allows you to read and write programmes accurately:

Notation	Meaning	Example
3×8	3 sets of 8 reps	Barbell row: 3×8
4×6-8	4 sets, 6 to 8 reps	Romanian deadlift: 4×6-8
3×8 @ 75% 1RM	3 sets, 8 reps at 75% of 1-rep max	Bench press: 3×8 @ 75%1RM
3×8 @ RPE 7	3 sets, 8 reps at Rate of Perceived Exertion 7/10	Squat: 3×8 RPE7

3×8 @RIR 3	3 sets, 8 reps, 3 reps in reserve	Row: 3×8 RIR3
A1/A2	Paired exercises in superset	A1:Curl, A2:Tricep ext

RPE Scale — Autoregulation for Beginners

The Rate of Perceived Exertion (RPE) scale (Borg's 6–20 or Zourdos's 1–10 modified scale) allows autoregulation — adjusting load based on daily readiness rather than a fixed percentage:

RPE (1–10)	Description	Reps in Reserve (RIR)
10	Maximum effort — could not do another rep	0
9	Could do 1 more rep	1
8	Could do 2 more reps	2
7	Could do 3 more reps	3
6	Could do 4 more reps	4
5 and below	Warm-up territory	5+

For beginners: RPE 6–7 on working sets is appropriate. This ensures sufficient stimulus while maintaining form under fatigue. Moving to RPE 8+ should be gradual as technique becomes automatic — typically after 4–8 weeks.

SECTION 3: Training Splits

How to Organise Training Frequency

A training split determines which muscle groups or movements are trained on which days. The optimal split depends on training frequency, recovery capacity, schedule, and goal.

Split	Frequency	Who It Suits	Muscle Freq/Week
Full Body	2–4×/week	Beginners, <3 days/week	2–4×
Upper/Lower	4×/week	Intermediate, 4 days	2×
Push/Pull/Legs (PPL)	3–6×/week	Intermediate to advanced	1–2×
Body Part Split	5–6×/week	Advanced bodybuilders	1×
Hybrid (e.g. PHUL)	4×/week	Intermediate strength+hypertrophy	2×

Research consensus: Training each muscle group 2× per week produces greater hypertrophy than 1×/week with equal weekly volume. For beginners, full-body 3×/week provides 3× frequency — superior for motor learning and early neural adaptation.

Minimum Effective Dose (MED) for beginners: 10–12 sets per muscle per week is sufficient for near-maximal hypertrophic response. More is not always better — recovery must match stimulus.

SECTION 4: Compound vs Isolation Exercises

The Hierarchy of Exercise Selection

Exercises exist on a spectrum from multi-joint compounds to single-joint isolations. Both have a place in programming, but their priority and proportion should reflect the goal and training age of the individual.

Category	Definition	Examples	Best For
Primary compound	Multi-joint, >2 muscle groups, heavy load	Squat, deadlift, bench press, overhead press, pull-up	Strength, power, overall mass
Secondary compound	Multi-joint, moderate load	Lunge, incline DB press, dumbbell row, cable fly	Hypertrophy, targeted mass
Isolation	Single joint, 1–2 muscles	Bicep curl, tricep extension, lateral raise, leg extension	Targeted development, correction, rehab

80/20 rule for beginners: 80% of training volume from compound movements, 20% from isolation work. Compounds provide maximum caloric expenditure, hormonal response, and foundational strength.

Progressive model: Master compound movement pattern first (2–4 weeks), then add isolation work for lagging muscle groups once the foundation is stable.

SECTION 5: Warm-Up and Cool-Down Science

The Warm-Up — More Than Just Moving Around

A proper warm-up is a structured preparation protocol that optimises performance and reduces injury risk. It is NOT 5 minutes of cardio followed by static stretching — that outdated approach may actually impair performance.

The RAMP Protocol

Phase	Duration	Goal	Examples
R — Raise	5 min	Elevate heart rate, temperature, blood flow	Light cardio, jumping jacks, skipping
A — Activate	3–5 min	Wake up key stabilisers	Glute bridges, band walks, face pulls, dead bugs

M — Mobilise	3–5 min	Improve range of motion dynamically	Leg swings, hip circles, thoracic rotation, arm circles
P — Potentiate	2–3 min	CNS priming, movement prep	Light sets of the planned exercise, explosive jumps

Static stretching pre-workout: Sustained stretches of >30 seconds acutely reduce force production by 5–8% by decreasing musculotendinous stiffness. Reserve static stretching for the cool-down or separate flexibility sessions.

Dynamic warm-up superiority: Dynamic mobility drills maintain or enhance force production while improving ROM — making them the superior pre-training choice.

The Cool-Down

The cool-down helps return the body toward homeostasis, manage blood pooling (preventing post-exercise hypotension), and begin the recovery process:

- 5–10 min light activity (walking, light cycling) to gradually reduce HR
- Static stretching for tight areas (holds 30–60 seconds, 2–3 sets)
- Foam rolling / myofascial release for targeted tissue quality
- Breathing exercises to activate parasympathetic nervous system

SECTION 6: Building a 4-Week Beginner Programme

Sample 3-Day Full-Body Programme (Weeks 1–4)

This programme follows a Monday / Wednesday / Friday structure. It is built around five fundamental movement patterns: squat, hip hinge, vertical push, vertical pull, and horizontal push/pull.

Day A — Monday				
Exercise	**Sets**	**Reps**	**Rest**	**Notes**
Goblet Squat	3	10–12	90s	Heels elevated if needed; focus on depth
Romanian Deadlift	3	10–12	90s	Hip hinge pattern; soft knee
Dumbbell Bench Press	3	10–12	90s	Control the eccentric (3 sec down)
Seated Cable Row	3	10–12	90s	Retract scapulae; avoid shrugging
Dumbbell Overhead Press	3	10–12	90s	Neutral spine; brace core
Plank	3	30–45s	60s	Posterior pelvic tilt; breathe normally

Day B — Wednesday

Exercise	Sets	Reps	Rest	Notes
Barbell Back Squat	3	8–10	2 min	Or goblet squat if not comfortable with bar
Trap Bar Deadlift	3	8–10	2 min	Hip hinge; drive through heels
Incline Dumbbell Press	3	10–12	90s	30–45° incline; clavicular pec + anterior delt
Lat Pulldown (wide grip)	3	10–12	90s	Pull to upper chest; controlled return
Dumbbell Lateral Raise	3	15	60s	Slight forward lean; avoid shrug
Ab Wheel Rollout / Dead Bug	3	8–10	60s	Core anti-extension pattern

Day C — Friday				
Exercise	**Sets**	**Reps**	**Rest**	**Notes**
Leg Press	3	12–15	90s	Feet shoulder-width; full ROM
Nordic Hamstring Curl / Lying Leg Curl	3	10–12	90s	Slow eccentric; key for hamstring health
Push-Up (or weighted)	3	AMRAP	60s	Full ROM; rigid plank body
Assisted Pull-Up / Negative Pull-Up	3	8–10	90s	Work towards bodyweight pull-ups
Face Pull	3	15–20	60s	External rotation; rear delt + rotator cuff
Pallof Press	3	10 each side	60s	Core anti-rotation; standing or kneeling

Progression Model — Weeks 1–4

Week	Volume	Intensity	Focus
1	3 sets	RPE 6	Learn movement patterns — technique priority
2	3 sets	RPE 7	Add 2.5–5kg to most exercises if form holds
3	4 sets	RPE 7–8	Volume increase; note fatigue markers
4 (Deload)	2 sets	RPE 5–6	Allow recovery; set stage for next block

Module 3 Key Takeaways

• Training programmes provide structure, accountability, and a built-in progression model

• Sets, reps, and intensity must match the goal: strength (1–5, 85%+), hypertrophy (6–20, 65–85%), endurance (20+, <65%)

• Beginners benefit most from full-body 3×/week for motor learning and neural adaptation

• Compound exercises form the foundation; isolation work complements but doesn't replace them

• The RAMP warm-up outperforms traditional static stretching for performance and injury prevention
• Even a simple 3-day programme produces excellent results if applied consistently with progressive overload

Review Questions

1. What does RPE 8 mean, and how does autoregulation benefit beginners?

2. Why is a full-body 3× per week split superior to a body-part split for most beginners?

3. Explain why static stretching before training may impair performance.

4. What is the SAID principle, and how does it apply to exercise selection?

5. Design a progression model for a beginner who starts squatting 60kg for 3×8. What does the next 4 weeks look like?